



SANJAY SONKAR

Falling Out of Grace

LUCKNOW Hell hath no fury like a woman scorned, especially when she happens to be a chief minister. This was what Uttar Pradesh chief secretary Prashant Kumar Mishra discovered when he fell out from Mayawati. She had earlier persuaded him to lead the state administration when he was

the secretary, Panchayati Raj. It turned into the beginning of the end of his illustrious career. He was not briefed about cabinet notes and agendas, nor was he asked to attend meetings. Mishra's downfall began when he refused to endorse the state Government's decision to abolish outposts of the

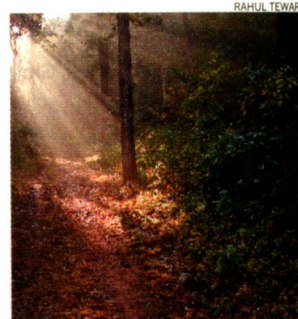
FORCED TO QUIT: Mishra trade tax, transport and the forest departments "as it would cause a revenue loss of hundreds of crores to the state", he had said.

His refusal to sign the Uttar Pradesh Control of Organised Crime Bill—which allowed the police to tap phones—also did not go down too well with Mayawati. When he objected to the excess allotment of land for the development of a university, the Grand Dame asked Mishra to opt for a posting of his choice in a clear indication that she wanted him out. "Having worked at the top post there was no question of me joining anywhere else," says Mishra. He took voluntary retirement, something that no other chief secretary has ever done in the state.

by Subhash Mishra

Cutting Edge

MUMBAI Chopping trees illegally will soon invite a 10-year jail term in Maharashtra. Unable to stop the felling of trees, state Forest Minister Babanrao Pachpute is planning to amend the Forest Act to press charges of culpable homicide not amounting to murder against people



RAHUL TEWARI

GREEN LIFE: Saving trees caught chopping trees without permission. To spread awareness and educate people on the importance of a green cover, the minister has set up committees at the village level.

However, indiscriminate felling of trees continues across the state. The proposal, which is yet to be placed for approval by the Cabinet, doesn't have too many takers. "Instead of introducing new laws, we should strengthen the existing Acts to take action. They should increase fine amounts according to the number of trees chopped. There should be a process of deliberation with horticulture departments, activists, lawmakers and builders," says environmentalist Rishi Aggarwal. The current fine for cutting down a tree is a meagre Rs 500, which is hardly a deterrent for illegal woodcutters.

by Aditi Pal

Hard Attack

HYDERABAD Activists of the Madiga Reservation Porata Samithi (MRPS) armed with sticks and petrol bottles went on a rampage at the office of the Telugu daily *Andhra Jyothi*. They were protesting against what they call an incorrect report on the corrupt practices of caste based organisations and emerging caste-inspired political equations in the state published by the paper. In simultaneous attacks, MRPS cadres burnt newspaper copies in front of the offices of *Andhra Jyothi* in Visakhapatnam, Warangal and Sangareddy. "Our daily does not have any community bias and attacking the office is not a way to



A PRABHAKAR RAO

discuss an issue," says *Andhra Jyothi*'s Managing Director V. Radhakrishna. The report did not name anyone but alluded to leaders of caste cohorts who shifted stands and changed their demands for financial and personal ends. The MRPS contends that much of the reservation quota for SCs in Andhra Pradesh is cornered by the Mala community. "This newspaper

is run by forward castes who want to create friction among Dalits," says MRPS leader Krishna Madiga. An embarrassed Information and Public Relations Minister Anam Ramnarayan Reddy countered, "The press enjoys constitutional protection and the state Government would take all steps to ensure freedom of the press."

by Amarnath K. Menon